



THE PALISADES FIRE burns in Malibu on Jan. 8. Researchers are tracking the extent that chemicals from the blaze reach the ocean.

Inside intense inquiry into fire

Federal investigators in the Palisades have focused on a hillside. An earlier blaze may hold important clues.

By RICHARD WINTON AND HANNAH FRY

For the last few weeks, a team of investigators from the U.S. Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms and Explosives has worked out of a command post in the Highlands neighborhood of Pacific Palisades.

It's here, near a popular hiking trail, where officials believe the Palisades fire began around 10:30 a.m. Jan. 7. The remnants of thousands of burned-out homes line the path the flames took down from the hillside as it charged all the way to the ocean.

But the cause remains a mystery that this team is trying to solve.

Investigators have scoured each part of the trail and hillside, breaking it down into a grid. They have examined 250 leads, obtained 90 hours of relevant video and conducted 50 interviews.

Fifteen ATF team members across the country with various science backgrounds armed with high-tech mapping, drones and a portable lab are aiding in the investigation, officials said.

ATF officials declined to provide information about what they suspect started the Palisades fire, which charred 23,400 acres and leveled more than 6,800 structures, including many homes.

But sources with knowledge of the inquiry said there are two leading theories: An 8-acre blaze that fire officials thought they had put out on Jan. 1 in the same area reignited and spread because of intense winds, or a new fire was somehow sparked nearby that morning. Sources have told The Times the blaze appears to have human origins.

The Los Angeles Fire Department declined to answer specific questions about the Jan. 1 blaze, called the Lachman fire, saying the [See Investigation, A7]

Blazes may worsen ocean pollution

The Reuben Lasker was about four miles off the coast of Manhattan Beach when ash began to rain upon the sea — first in delicate flurries, then in noxious clouds.

The fisheries research vessel had set sail days earlier for a coastal survey. It was supposed to be a routine voyage, the kind that the California Cooperative Oceanic Fisheries Investigations program, or CalCOFI, embarks upon four times a year as part of the world's longest-running marine ecosystem monitoring effort.

But when the Palisades and Eaton fires broke out, scientists aboard the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration ship inadvertently became the first investigators on the scene of a brewing disaster that could upend life underwater.

The smoke that has choked Los Angeles, the debris piled up along decimated streets, the charred and toxic remnants of thousands of destroyed homes, businesses, cars and electronics — nearly all of it, eventually, will come to rest in the ocean.

There is no precedent for how an urban fire of this magnitude could change the ecosystem that countless species, including our own, rely

Scientists will use long-term data to determine whether toxic debris could create a disaster for sea life

By CORINNE PURTILL AND ROSANNA XIA



MEMBERS of the California Conservation Corps place barriers to contain contaminants in Pacific Palisades on Tuesday.

on for food and sustenance.

But there's also no team better equipped to understand how the fires that transformed Los Angeles will affect life in the sea.

Unlike the smoke that emanates from rural wildfires, the charred material now entering the ocean is the stuff of "people's homes: their cars, their batteries, their electronics," said Rasmus Swalethorp, a biological oceanographer at UC San Diego's Scripps Institution of Oceanography. "It's certainly going to contain a lot of things that we ideally don't want to see in our oceans — and in our soils, for that matter, and our water streams, and certainly not on our dinner plates."

CalCOFI was formed in 1949 to study the collapse of the sardine industry, in a joint effort by Scripps, NOAA Fisheries and state fish and wildlife officials. Scientists quickly realized that question could be answered only by studying the interconnected layers of the broader marine ecosystem.

CalCOFI began to methodically collect detailed ocean samples from the same 113 locations multiple times a year, along a systematic grid that spans the California coast. Millions [See Pollution, A7]

Why FDA took so long to ban red dye No. 3

By KAREN KAPLAN

The Food and Drug Administration said earlier this month that the much-maligned red dye No. 3 would be banned in the United States because it has been shown to cause cancer in animals.

The decision, lauded by consumer advocacy groups, comes a full 25 years after scientists at the agency determined that rats who were fed large amounts of the artificial color additive were much more likely to develop malignant thyroid tumors than rats who weren't given the food coloring. The rats who ate it also had an increased incidence of benign tumors and growths that can be precursors to cancer.

Those findings prompted the FDA to declare in 1990 that red dye No. 3 could not be used in cosmetics or drugs applied to the skin. The reason for the decision was clear: A federal law known as the Delaney clause [See Red dye No. 3, A10]



ROBERT F. KENNEDY JR., President Trump's health secretary pick, defended his views on vaccines.

Senators confront Kennedy in fiery hearing

By SEEMA MEHTA AND KAREN KAPLAN

WASHINGTON — Robert F. Kennedy Jr., who has pledged to "make America healthy again" as President Trump's secretary of Health and Human Services, faced aggressive questions Wednesday from senators who were troubled by his skepticism of vaccines, embrace of debunked

medical claims, financial conflicts of interest and 11th-hour changes on issues such as abortion rights.

Kennedy portrayed himself as an advocate for regular folks who feel outgunned by entrenched interests.

"In my advocacy, I've often disturbed the status quo by asking uncomfortable questions," the Brentwood resident said. "Well, I'm not going to apologize [See RFK, A5]

Trump's first orders test the constitutional limit of presidential powers

He's likely to succeed on some fronts, but others, like birthright citizenship, may be out of his realm.

By DAVID G. SAVAGE

WASHINGTON — President Trump has begun his second term pressing his power to reshape the government by firing federal officials, ending diversity policies and deporting immigrants who are in this country illegally.

Despite fierce criticism, he is likely to succeed on those fronts because the Constitution and the laws generally put those powers in the hands of the president.

"Under our Constitution, the executive power — all of it — is vested in a president," Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. said in 2020. And that includes the president's nearly "unrestricted remov-

al power" of officials throughout the government, he said.

The court's conservative majority has also struck down racial diversity policies in universities and said repeatedly that the president has broad authority to enforce immigration laws.

In some areas, however, Trump appears to be claiming powers that go well beyond the president's authority set out in the Constitution.

He says he can, by executive order, rewrite the 14th Amendment of 1868 and deny citizenship to some children who are born in the United States to parents who are not citizens.

And this week, the White House claimed the power to temporarily freeze federal spending that has been approved by Congress to see whether it is aligned with "presidential priorities."

On Wednesday, the White House quickly rescinded the freeze memo that set off alarm and confusion across [See Trump, A5]

English, math test scores fall

Fewer fourth- and eighth-graders meet "basic" ranking in L.A., state and nationwide, report says. **NATION, A5**

A Lakers trade would be tricky

Options are complex and expensive for front office as deadline for a deal looms. **SPORTS, B10**

Edison seeks OK to raise its rates

Utility wants customers to cover \$7 billion in damages linked to its equipment in 2017, 2018 fires. **BUSINESS, A6**

Weather Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 60/44. **B6**

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